

Your Blog, Explained Simply

An owner's guide: how it works, how to duplicate it for a client, what accounts you need, and how to keep it safe for years.

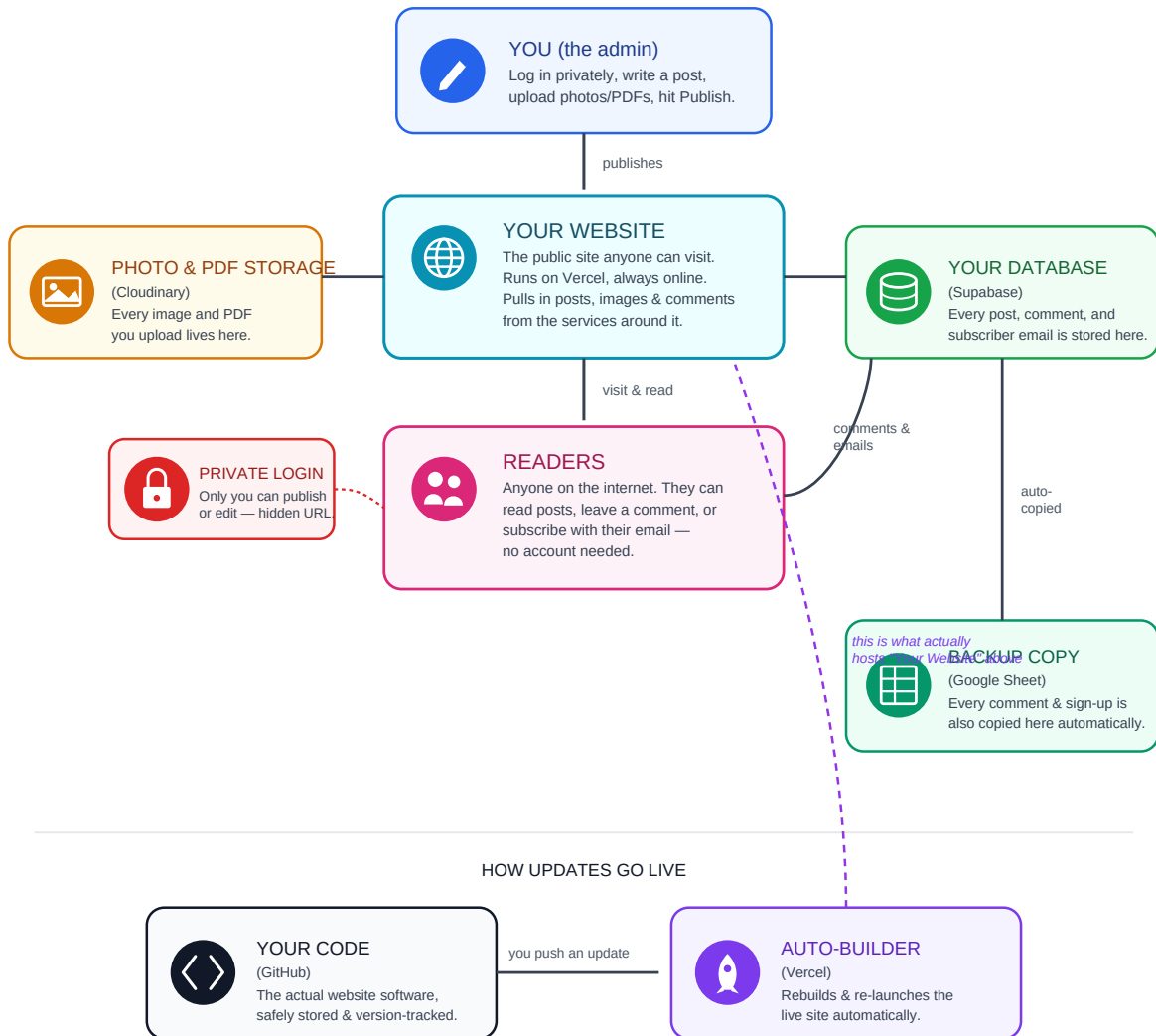
This is written for a non-technical reader — you. No jargon without an explanation. Keep this file for yourself, and hand a copy to any client you set this up for.

The Big Picture

Your website isn't one single thing — it's a small team of free online services working together. Here's every piece, and how they connect. (Full diagram on the next page.)

How Your Blog Actually Works

A plain-English map of every moving part



You never touch servers directly — every box above is a free-tier account you control from its own dashboard.

Duplicating This for a New Client

This whole project was built as a template on purpose. One client's website should never affect another's — each one gets its own separate copy of everything below.

1 **Make a fresh copy of the code**

On GitHub, use “Use this template” (or just copy the project folder) to create a brand-new, separate copy for this client. Think of it like photocopying a binder — the original stays untouched.

2 **Give the client their own set of free accounts**

They need their own Supabase (database), Cloudinary (photo/PDF storage), and Vercel (hosting) accounts — never reuse yours for a different client. See the checklist on the next page for exactly what each one is.

3 **Change one file to make it theirs**

Open `lib/site-config.ts` and swap in their name, tagline, short bio, and topic list. That one file is the only place their brand identity lives — nothing else needs editing.

4 **Connect their database**

Paste their new Supabase connection details into the project's settings file (called `.env`), then run two short setup commands once. This creates all the empty tables the site needs — for posts, comments, subscribers, and so on.

5 **Set their admin login**

Pick an email and a strong password for them (or let them pick), put it in that same settings file, and run the setup command. That becomes their private key to the admin area.

6 **Put it online**

Connect the new code copy to a new Vercel project. Vercel gives it a free web address immediately; if they own a domain name (like `theirname.com`), point it there in a few clicks.

7 **Walk through it together once**

Log in as them, publish a test post, leave a comment as a visitor, then delete the test post. Two minutes, and it confirms everything is wired up correctly before you hand it over.

Every Account You'll Need

All of these have a free tier that's more than enough for a personal or small-business blog. Nothing here requires a credit card unless noted.

Account	What it's actually for	Cost
GitHub	Where the website's code lives, safely stored and backed up.	Free
Vercel	Hosts the live website — this is what makes it visible on the internet, 24/7.	Free
Supabase	The database — stores every post, comment, and subscriber email.	Free
Cloudinary	Stores uploaded photos and PDF attachments.	Free
Google Cloud (optional)	Only if you want comments/subscriber emails auto-copied into a Google Sheet as a backup.	Free
Domain name (optional)	A custom web address like yourname.com instead of the free yourname.vercel.app one.	~\$10–\$15/yr
Admin login	Not a company account — just an email + password you invent yourself. This is what lets you (or the client) log in to write posts.	Free

Rule of thumb: one client = one full set of these accounts, all separate from every other client's. Never mix two clients' data into the same Supabase project or Cloudinary account.

Keeping It Running for Years, Hands-Off

The good news: there is no physical server to maintain, no software to update, and nothing that “wears out.” Vercel and Supabase run the actual computers for you, permanently, as part of their free plan.

Here's what that really means:

- **No renewals needed for hosting or the database.**

Vercel and Supabase's free tiers don't expire on a timer. As long as the account exists and isn't deleted, the site keeps running — you don't need to click anything monthly or yearly.

- **The one thing that DOES need yearly renewal: the domain name.**

If you bought a custom address like yourname.com, that's rented yearly from a domain registrar. Turn on auto-renew when you buy it, and put a reminder on the calendar anyway as a backup.

- **Free tiers have soft limits, not cliffs.**

If a blog gets unusually popular (way more visitors or storage than a normal personal site), the free tier might ask you to upgrade to a small paid plan — typically \$10–\$25/month. For a normal blog this essentially never happens.

- **The real risk is losing access to the accounts themselves.**

Use an email address you'll always control, write down which email each account uses, and store the passwords somewhere safe (a password manager, not a sticky note). This matters far more than anything technical.

Keeping It Secure

Security here mostly comes down to a handful of things already built in, plus a couple of habits on your end.

Already built in, automatically:

- Every visitor's connection is encrypted (the padlock icon in the browser) — Vercel handles this for free, no setup needed.
- The admin login page isn't linked anywhere public — visitors browsing the site have no way to stumble onto it.
- All passwords and secret keys (database, image storage, etc.) are stored as hidden “environment variables,” never visible in the website's actual code.
- Only someone with the exact admin email and password can publish, edit, or delete a post — there's no other way in.
- A reader deleting their own comment can only ever delete their own — never anyone else's.

Habits worth keeping:

- Use a real, unique password for the admin login — not something guessable, and not reused from another site.
- Don't share the admin password over chat or email in plain text if you can avoid it.
- If you ever hand the site fully over to a client, change the admin password afterward so you no longer have their login.
- Keep the project's “.env” settings file private — it's already excluded from the code that gets shared/published, but never paste its contents somewhere public.

In short: nothing here needs a technical team to keep running. Renew the domain name once a year, keep your account passwords safe, and everything else takes care of itself.